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Mark Soskin

Pianist and composer Mark Soskin has collaborated with a distinguished group of jazz artists, including Sonny Rollins, Billy Cobham and Bennie Maupin. Mark has recorded as a leader on SteepleChase Records and currently teaches at the Manhattan School of Music.

Mark was interviewed via Zoom on September 17, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm very pleased to have Mark Soskin with me this morning, keyboardist and jazz educator and recording artist. And we chatted before we sort "rolled tape" here and you have a positive outlook on your career in general.

MS: I do.

MR: Yeah, it seems to be challenging but you seem to have done all right.

MS: Oh I have. You know I mean besides Sonny Rollins I played with well Stanley Turrentine, Billy Cobham, you know a bunch of people. And I saw that on one of your shows you had Orrin Keepnews, right? And Orrin was my first producer on my first record. Okay? So one thing led to another. I mean first what happened was that I was scheduled to play with the CBS All Stars, a group called the CBS All Stars and they were all all-stars and I wasn't. So I went up to Bruce Lundvall, then the head of Columbia Records. I said, "Hey Bruce, they're all all-stars and I'm not, so what are we going to do?" And right there he said, "Well why don't you go in and do a demo. Put down the money." And I did a demo and it got rejected from Columbia but I went to Orrin Keepnews and I got hired on the spot and that was it. That was the start of my career.

MR: Was that Fantasy Records?

MS: It was Fantasy.

MR: Yeah.

MS: The record came out on Prestige and that was, you know, a little subsidiary of Fantasy you know.

MR: Right. Well he certainly, Orrin must have recognized something in you that he liked right away and also he might have sensed there's some longevity here.

MS: Yes. But it was only one record. I was scheduled to do another record but, and I had all the musicians, I had, you know the compositions. But that never happened for some reason or another. But look I'm still recording. I've done four CDs for SteepleChase, here's one of them. This is my last record. It's called "Ballad for a Rainy Afternoon." And I'm still working on, I still compose like crazy. I do a lot of composing.

MR: Yeah, we're going to talk about that, I have some questions about that. I wanted to go back a little bit to the early 70s and from what I read about you you were studying classical music but attracted to jazz. And when I think of the early 70s I mean jazz fusion and jazz rock was in full bloom.

MS: Yes it was.

MR: So I'm wondering, the jazz that you were attracted to and maybe pulled you away from classical, was it jazz fusion or was it more like the masters, the —

MS: Yeah it was more of the masters. You know jazz, the only reason I'm associated with jazz fusion was because of Billy Cobham. And at that time Billy Cobham was very popular and so we used to tour a lot. But I was really into, I don't know, Sonny Rollins. You know that's what I really liked to do. So you know I went from there to playing with Sonny.

MR: How would — you would have been in your early twenties?

MS: Well we're talking about like 1977, 78. Yes. My early twenties.

MR: Were you thinking to yourself, questioning whether you were in over your head?

MS: Never.

MR: Good for you.

MS: No, no. I always knew what I was doing and hopefully still do.

MR: Well it's so interesting. I had quite a number of Sonny Rollins records and I just yesterday watched a good deal of the video "Saxophone Colossus."

MS: That's the one where he jumps off the —

MR: Yes.

MS: I was there.

MR: And did you know he hurt himself?

MS: Well what happened was that you know we're playing and all of a sudden he jumps off the thing and we had no idea what was going on. And we were laughing. And then when we — at the end they said, "There's not going to be an encore, we have to take Sonny away." And he broke his heel.

MR: I was fascinated by that, you know he's doing his thing where he's playing solo and in this one section he goes from "Give Me a Kiss to Build a Dream On" to something from the "Peer Gynt Suite" to the "The Flying Young Man" or the Flying Trapeze or whatever.

MS: Right before he did that he quoted "The Man on the Flying Trapeze."

MR: Okay.

MS: And that's why that happened, and then he jumped.

MR: So as a musician myself I sometimes wonder, I'm not sure that you or your bandmates at that time would have admitted it, but did you ever feel like, "Uh Mr. Rollins, we've been sitting here for a long time and we haven't been playing anything, could we play now?"

MS: Well I mean he was always playing, and we knew what to get into if he'd start something you know we'd get into it. Like if he started — whatever — "My One and Only Love" or something like that, we'd pick up on that.

MR: Okay. So you were waiting — he's doing his thing, he's quoting these songs, and at some point he starts playing a song in a fashion that it's your job, because you've been paying attention, now we join in.

MS: That's right. Yep. And you know I'm currently at — this is another thing — currently when I'm teaching now at Manhattan School of Music, which I started yesterday by the way, today I'm doing another class in improvisation. But when I was doing this yesterday this is the music of Sonny Rollins. This is the band. And I brought all the music because I still have all his music that I've kept and it's in his handwriting. And the students just love that.

MR: I'll bet.

MS: And we came up with a set list and now we're getting into the tunes.

MR: Awww. That's awesome. I mean that's pulling real life experience into the classroom which I think is so important.

MS: Absolutely. Oh yeah. I mean look, we're talking about Sonny Rollins. He's like one of the last ones like this, alive. And you know, and to see the music in his handwriting, that's something special.

MR: Yeah. You hold on to that.

MS: I am holding on to it. I have it right here. I have tons of it. You know and he'd send me the letters, you know letters that he wrote. I still have that too and I showed it to my students. And you know what can you say?

MR: Did he tell you or suggest things about your playing that he wanted you to do or did he leave you to your own devices?

MS: Okay what he liked was simple chords, not really substitute chords or anything like that. He just wanted the basic thing. And when I would solo, that was up to me. So when I played, it was just the basics. And we took it from there.

MR: I wonder if you, when you're backing him up or other horn players, do you ever lay out like on purpose?

MS: Yeah. Well sometimes I mean tonight I'm playing with an amazing tenor saxophone player, Rich Perry. And you know we're doing all my music. And so sometimes I'll lay out but we're doing my music so it's got to be, you know, together.

MR: Okay. Yeah you might want to be in — I'll tell you the reason I asked that question. I very much enjoyed your recording on "Walk Tall."

MS: Oh. "Walk Tall."

MR: Yeah.

MS: That was my first record.

MR: And there's a point there, you know the band is like it's so funky and then there's a point where you're soloing with only the drums.

MS: Right. Exactly.

MR: And I love that because it's like a different sound, a different texture, and then when the bass and etcetera come back in it's like oh yeah.

MS: Uh huh. Yeah. Well that was how I wanted it. That was pretty much it. And you know to this day I mean I enjoy that kind of playing, you know where I'm just soloing with one other person you know. And I still love to do that.

MR: Why do you think your, I'm looking at your list from your website as a sideman, which runs close to one hundred and probably more than that now.

MS: Yeah. Say that again?

MR: Your list of sidemen, okay.

MS: Here it is, "Walk Tall."

MR: All right, okay.

MS: That's right. I mean for this record I specifically, I mean because Orrin said, he said basically get who you want. And I wanted, at the time, Bennie Maupin, Harvey Mason, you know it was Herbie's band you know. And so I got these guys and that was, you know, it was great. And "Walk Tall" that was that.

MR: Why do you think people, I mean your list of recordings as a sideman for one thing is close to one hundred or maybe over that by now.

MS: Probably more.

MR: Yeah. How come you get all those calls? If you think about yourself as a player and as a participant do you know why people call you so often?

MS: I do and that's because I can do a lot of different things. You know a lot of different kinds of music I can do. And I tell that to my students, I mean the more you could do the more work you're going to get.

MR: Have you had students who have had a chance to play like club dates or weddings or something and they have an attitude about it? They sort of turn up their nose at, oh gee —

MS: Well that's not good. You know I mean if you have that attitude you're really going to miss out on a lot of stuff. Because you've got to be open to different kinds of music and that's one of the reasons I work so much.

MR: What about the non-musical parts of the music business. How do you teach your students the importance of things like punctuality and attitude?

MS: Well that comes into the picture. Not right away but I will get to it with them you know, and that's definitely an important thing. And one of the things why I kept the gig with

Sonny was punctuality. I mean if he's leaving to go to the gig from the hotel, you better be down there, 'cause if you're not, you're fired.

MR: He always struck me as, oh gosh I'm not sure how to put this, a little mysterious.

MS: Yes.

MR: Like he was a sage and he knew things that most of us don't.

MS: Yeah, he knew what he wanted, and he knew what he wanted out of the musicians you know. And one thing that I brought up to my students yesterday in my class was that if you didn't know calypso music, especially a drummer, forget about it. You weren't hired. Period.

MR: Especially what did you say?

MS: Especially drummers.

MR: Oh drummers, yeah, okay.

MS: If they couldn't play calypso music, forget about it.

MR: Yeah because that was —

MS: He had to have calypso music, because we always did calypsos. I mean that was kind of our theme song was "Don't Stop the Carnival" from the record "Don't Stop the Carni —" that was the first record that I did with Sonny and that was with Tony Williams and Donald Byrd. And so, it's important.

MR: Well let's talk about your composing a little bit. Where do your ideas come from?

MS: That's a good question. Where do my ideas — you know it's really tricky. I just sit down at the piano and come up with something. And hopefully I don't throw it away 'cause I like to keep the idea fresh. And once I have that idea then I can build on it. You know like I have this tune called "Man Behind the Curtain." Yeah. "Man Behind the Curtain." And that's like a specific idea and it's in 3/4 and so I build on that. You know. And so it's really funny how that happens you know.

MR: When you have a tune that you've started, and then okay business calls, you've got to go teach a class, you've got to go play a gig, does that tune rattle around in your head until you can come back to it?

MS: Yes it does and eventually I'll get there.

MR: At what point do you name things?

MS: That's another interesting question. I really don't know. I mean well one thing, I have a tune called "Throwing Caution to the Wind." And that speaks for itself you know, the title, it's like throwing caution to the wind. So you're just letting it happen, taking chances.

MR: Do you feel that the song reflects that in its music?

MS: I do.

MR: Is it adventurous sort of?

MS: Yeah, I do. That kind of feel you know. If I was playing it now you'd hear it.

MR: I've often wondered, you read a lot, when people write about jazz, not necessarily musicians writing about jazz, that improvising is just playing what you feel. And I've often wondered if a professional musician such as yourself, if you had a really bad day and you had a lot of concerns on your mind but you had to go play a gig,

MS: Right.

MR: Do you think you would play differently than if you had had a terrific day? Does your state of mind affect your improvising?

MS: No. I'll say that. No it's just you know if I feel like warmed up and ready to do the music, you know because I've been practicing for this gig for quite some time, and I feel like I'm just ready to do it. You know now I really, tonight I'm just going to play. There's no thinking involved. It's like you think for a little bit and then you forget about your thinking you know. It's like you just play.

MR: I'd like to pursue that thinking business a little bit, because as a player myself I find that I have to do a certain amount of thinking if I'm playing a song that has some significant chord changes to it.

MS: Yes.

MR: I have to make the changes. But people like yourself they're saying well you should be beyond that. You should have absorbed it.

MS: Well yeah but you know what? It always changes when you're practicing to say when you're playing with the group. You know so it's really different practicing by yourself than playing with a band. It's different.

MR: That's very true.

MS: And so you know I'll work on, say I'm doing a modal tune, I'll work on playing in a modal when there's a modal chord, say where D Phrygian is, something like that, then I'll work on Phrygian mode and play through it until I really get that under my belt so to speak.

MR: What does playing through it mean to you? Like obviously you're not going to stick with the notes particular to the G Phrygian scale, you're going to go other places. And do you have a list of places that you can go in your head?

MS: Yes. I do.

MR: Could I have it please?

MS: Well I mean you know I mean I'll play like approach notes say, say things that get me to a certain place but it's not so cut and dry, you know you really have to play on it and see what you get out of it. So there's a lot that goes into it.

MR: If you were playing for your students, maybe in a private lesson or something, and you were sort of demonstrating that, and a student said, "Well Mr. Soskin that note you

played right there, why isn't that a mistake? You're playing in a certain key and you played that note like how come you can get away with that?"

MS: Because you have to make it right. You have to make the wrong note sound right. You have to convince the person or people that this is the right thing to play. You know it works on this chord. You know? And I'll have to do that tonight. I'll have to make it work.

MR: I've noticed that a lot, not a lot, but frequently with for instance Miles Davis, that he'll play, especially like at the ends of phrases he'll choose a note or play a note that boy I wish I could think of something like that, but I'm not sure I would dare play it.

MS: Yeah well try to do it. Find out. You know I mean if you want to create music it's taking risks. And that risk taking is often what makes the thing happen. You know just throwing caution to the wind, again.

MR: Have you ever had a circumstance where a sideman on your gig, your music, and they're throwing caution to the wind and have you ever thought like they're going a little too far with your music?

MS: Well not really because I'm always choosing musicians who I know will take care of business. I always know that they're going to do what I like them to do. You know say Jay Anderson for one, the bass player. You know I get him because I know what he's going to do. I know kind of the way he plays and I know the way Matt Wilson plays. And I know how Rich Perry plays you know so I know what they're going to do.

MR: Oh Matt Wilson, yeah. He's marvelous.

MS: He's been on a few of my records.

MR: What's it like now to land a gig in a New York City club?

MS: What is it like now?

MR: What's it — is it a chore? Is it, there's a lot of competition for these things?

MS: No. I mean not for me.

MR: Okay.

MS: I mean I usually, all I have to do these days, "Hey I played with Sonny Rollins." I get the gig right away. Everybody knows Sonny Rollins.

MR: Nice.

MS: And that's it. So there's really, I mean the reason I got this teaching gig doing the Music of Sonny Rollins, because I played with him. And you know I wouldn't have gotten the gig I think if I didn't play with him.

MR: How has the business changed? You've been a professional musician for —

MS: A long time.

MR: A long time. And you've been in a couple of cities but mostly in New York for long time. How has the business changed for you and your bandmates?

MS: Well how has the business changed?

MR: Well is there like — if you went to a bar to hang out with fellows you've known for a long time, do you engage in the "good old days"? Gee remember when we could do this and now that's gone — those kind of conversations?

MS: Well I mean it is gone in a way. But it still doesn't really affect me playing at places. But the business has changed. It definitely has changed.

MR: Can you elaborate on that?

MS: Well I don't think anybody could just go out there and get a record date, but somehow I've managed to do that.

MR: The days of, like I'm fond of the Cannonball Adderley story where he shows up in New York and sits in with Oscar Pettiford and next thing you know he's got a record contract.

MS: I mean because I played with Sonny Rollins, that's a good reason why I got a record contract.

MR: Do you have advice for your students about how to make their way in the business now?

MS: Yeah. Go to clubs, sit in with people, you know I mean like tonight after I play there's going to be a jam session there, at Small's. And I say go down to the club and make yourself known. Let other people hear what you do and so maybe if the club owner is there he could hear what you do and hopefully you'll be working at the club.

MR: So in order for them to make a good showing do you tell them you'd better know this list of tunes?

MS: Yes. Well repertoire is definitely important. So I mean look, Sonny knew so many tunes, you know ridiculous. He knew so many tunes, not only knew the tunes but knew them in several keys. So I would tell people learn the tunes and learn them in several different keys. And that's very important to do.

MR: Have you ever had a student go to one of those things and come in the next day and say oh, I really blew it?

MS: That can happen. That can definitely happen. I mean look, when I first got the call to do Sonny's, come down to Fantasy Records and do this audition. An "audition" it was called. When I got to the studio, at 12 midnight, there was nobody there except Orrin and Sonny. That's it. What am I going to do? I have to play? You know this is like I could get the gig. So you know you really have to just make the most of it. You know and I knew at the time that this was a big thing. And so when I went to do the audition I didn't know every tune that Sonny called, but I knew a lot of them. I knew enough of them to get me the gig. And right after I auditioned Sonny goes, "Okay, you got the gig and we're going to rehearse in a day or so" and that's that. So right away I was thrown into Tony Williams on one side and Sonny Rollins on the other, and throw in Donald Byrd in there. And so I

had to be ready for this. I mean I was a lot younger then you know, and I really had to take care of business immediately.

MR: Well speaking of taking care of business, I mean this may sound like an "of course not" question but would it occur to you at that moment where Sonny said "Okay you got the gig" do you — at what point do you ask about money?

MS: Okay. Well you know what I never asked about money. Because I just always figured it would be okay. And you know it was okay. And look Sonny at one point you know he was going to go out and do a world tour. And we rehearsed one time and then it all got canceled. And that was that last time he played, and that was the last time I played with him. But you know what? He paid me for the missing — he paid me a good amount of money to — you missed the gig, it was canceled, here's the money. He's a mensch.

MR: That's very classy.

MS: Very.

MR: Yeah 'cause you had set aside those dates and probably turned down other work.

MS: And did that. But you know when he called you had to be there you know. That was it. You know and so there was no question about that.

MR: Have you had people, maybe Sonny Rollins, other people that taught you life lessons as well as musical lessons?

MS: Well the life lessons were don't mess up. You know don't get drunk on the gig or whatever. Just yeah, I mean just do what you do and do it the best you can do it.

MR: Tell me about playing with Herbie Mann if you don't mind.

MS: Yeah.

MR: He was a favorite of mine back then.

MS: I played a lot with Herbie and yeah, at one time I was playing with Herbie, Stanley Turrentine and Sonny at the same time. And so it was great. I loved it. Mainly with Herbie it was playing Brazilian music and that's pretty much what we did, Brazilian music. I mean Stanley completely different. It was like about — well I remember Stanley used to do "My Romance." That was like his big tune that he used to do. And the sound that he had was so great — you know it was just heavenly.

MR: You probably played "Sugar" a few times.

MS: I played "Sugar," yes. That was a must-do. So you know if you're playing with somebody like that there's certain things you really need to know.

MR: Did you find that you played in different parts of the piano behind a flute player as opposed to a tenor sax player?

MS: Definitely. Oh for sure. Now if you're playing behind a flute player you've got to play pretty soft. So you know you've got to be aware of that, the dynamics. And I just did it.

MR: What about playing behind singers?

MS: Very important and that I still do. I still play the — I'm like the musical director for Roseanna Vitro. And there was one record we did, the music of Randy Newman, and that was nominated for a Grammy. And so playing behind a singer is something very specific. You can't get in the way of the singer — of the vocal. And you've got to know what to do with that.

MR: Yeah that's a whole other class in itself. You could have a vocal accompaniment class it seems to me.

MS: Yes. It's a whole art form. It's an art form to play behind a singer. Yup.

MR: I find it's tricky when you're playing behind a singer and all you have are chord charts.

MS: Yup.

MR: Because if you don't know what the melody is, how are you going to keep out of the way of the melody unless you know it.

MS: Well hopefully the vocalist will write in the chart the melody so, you know, that's very very important.

MR: Yeah. Have you ever had a singer say can I sing with you and you go sure, and they'll mention a song and you go what key and they go, "Well my first note is [hums]"?

MS: Well hopefully I'll grab it from that. I mean you know not all the time does that happen but, it can happen.

MR: I wonder if we're at a point with jazz education, you know the academic level has been around long enough that sometimes we have professors who didn't have the opportunity to actually play a lot of gigs.

MS: Yeah.

MR: And you're bringing that as a huge part of your resume so I don't really have a question here except to acknowledge that I think it's really important.

MS: What is important?

MR: That you have real-life knowledge of playing gigs and dealing with singers and everything we've been talking about.

MS: Yeah dealing with the whole picture. Yeah I've been fortunate, I've been lucky enough and you know I've worked very hard at this. You know like well I've had the opportunity to play with some great people and I've taken advantage of it.

MR: Can you describe to me if I looked, I'm looking at your sideman list right now and I'll pick okay Jimmy Ponder.

MS: Jimmy Ponder okay. Great.

MR: So you get a call — tell me how that whole thing works.

MS: Okay so I got a call from — who did I get it from — well I got a call from he was the bass player I think on that record, or something like that. And he said, "Yeah I've got this record date coming up and it's for Jimmy Ponder, you want to do it?" I said, "Yeah, sure

I'd love to do it. I know Jimmy Ponder's music." And so then what I did, I started checking out Jimmy's music and trying to see what I could do with it. I remember we did, on that record date, "The Creator Has a Master Plan." And you know that's really not a typical tune you would do. But you know I knew about it enough where I could do something with it. And that was great. I believe the bass player on that record was Peter Washington I think. And oh, and the drummer was the guy who played on "Song for my Father." The drummer from that record.

MR: Oh I should know this. I'm not passing the audition at the moment.

MS: But anyway it was that drummer. So it was a nice band.

MR: I just heard that recording by the way on my, whatever delivery system I have, Pandora or something. And I heard his version of that. So I was just listening to you a couple of days ago.

MS: Oh really.

MR: And when you have a tune like that, that's long, lengthy vamps, and the harmonic material is let's say limited, how do you expand on that without — you have to keep the music in mind and respect the composition.

MS: Yup. Definitely.

MR: So how do you build on those two vamping chords?

MS: Yeah well you know I think it was in C minor and you know with the voicings you know you'd play certain voicings when it came to it, maybe fourth voicing. And then for soloing you know C minor, all the minor chords you'd use, the scales you know, all of that. And that has to do with improvising. You know that's pretty much what I'm going to do today when I teach this class is what scales go with the chords. And you have to know those chords. You have to know those scales. So I've done that work.

MR: Have you ever had a recording date where you were accompanying a singer or a soloist who was not even there? In other words you're laying down accompaniment for somebody to put something over it later?

MS: Like an overdub.

MR: Correct.

MS: And what's your question?

MR: My question is I wonder if you've ever been in that situation like you're comping but you don't know what's going to go over the top of this.

MS: Right.

MR: So it's kind of an odd feeling that I can't respond to the soloist or the singer because they're going to do this later.

MS: Yeah. I mean usually when I do a record date it's really not so much about that.

MR: Okay.

MS: It's not so much about overdubbing. It's live. We're all playing live and I know what to do.

MR: Okay. Are you able to keep track pretty well of your business dealings like have you ever had a circumstance where like gee I played that record date like six months ago and I haven't received anything for it. Are you on top of that kind of thing in your career?

MS: Received anything?

MR: Like you didn't get paid.

MS: Oh. Not getting paid is always not good. And I always keep that stuff in mind. Oh yeah. Definitely. And usually that's done well in advance you know. So like I'll know what I'm going to get paid and I know what everybody else is going to get, you know? So now I'm doing this gig at Small's, I know how much they're going to get paid. And when I'm at the gig, here's what you're going to get. Boom. And I pay them. And usually they're very happy with what I pay them. And that's something else, you know, to have a band you're expected to really pay pretty well. You know? And usually it works. I mean with Sonny he's always paid me well. Stanley Turrentine? No. Stanley Turrentine I didn't get paid very well. And that was always an issue. And you know what? I one time, I said to Stanley, "Hey Stanley, I think we should get paid more." And from that day on he called me "The Squeeze." He said, "Man what are you trying to do, squeeze me?" And that was what I was called.

MR: Good. I'm going to add that to my vocabulary. The Squeeze. I noticed you've done some arranging, Slide Hampton and other people. Did you make a transition from using pencil and paper to using Finale or Sibelius?

MS: At one time I used Sibelius. I don't anymore. Now it's by hand. I gave that up. And I find it's fine. People who use Finale and Sibelius, but I don't now. It's just all hand written. And I try to make it really readable. And it seems to have worked.

MR: Do you think you have an accurate perception in your head what one of your arrangements is going to sound like before it gets played?

MS: I do. I do. I mean usually when I come up with an arrangement I have something very clear in my mind what it's going to sound like. And I worked at that.

MR: Yeah there's nothing like that feeling of working hard on a chart and the first time you hear it back played by live instruments you know, usually it's a wonderful feeling.

MS: It's really a good feeling. And you know on my very first record, on the "Rhythm Vision" that's when I first got into arranging. And I had a bunch of horns on that record. And I remember when I got it played and it turned out really well, I went wow, this is great. And from that day on, you know, that's been a big part of what I do. And actually I'd like to do another record that has a bunch of horns and do more of that.

MR: I imagine like most working musicians you have a list of players and you have your first choices and your second choices on every instrument.

MS: I do. That's very important. Yeah. I mean usually I use Jay Anderson on bass. I'm very comfortable playing with Jay. And drummers that's a little different, because I've worked with Matt Wilson a bunch but I've also worked with Adam Nussbaum a bunch. And so you know I've used Adam when I've gone on tour and so yeah, I have several musicians that I picked. And as far as tenor players or something like that, that's the same thing. You know I've used Bennie Maupin and he's great. I'm still in touch with Bennie.

MR: Is he a New York person?

MS: L.A.

MR: I see.

MS: Yeah he lives in L.A. but he's come to New York and I've met him here and we've talked about things, actually doing things again you know. Because I've always liked his playing, you know Bennie Maupin. It's great.

MR: Is there such a thing as, for you, like oh I can't get this bass player I want but you got the drummer you want but then the bass player you can get doesn't work well with the drummer you got? Does that happen?

MS: That could be sometimes, yeah. But not often does that happen.

MR: You mostly, my observation is that you mostly work with pros.

MS: Absolutely. I can work with nobody less than pros. They have to be pros and that's who I work with. That's about it.

MR: Can you recall ever playing a gig or a recording session that was just a real train wreck?

MS: Wow. I'd have to think about that one. Because usually that hasn't come up.

MR: That's good.

MS: Yeah usually what I'll do is get the music ahead of time to these guys and so that they have a little time to get into the music.

MR: Do you recall, I'm going back again to your college days, did your parents support your fascination with jazz?

MS: No. Absolutely not. You know what? Once I played Carnegie Hall and they came that was when they changed. They said he must be a good musician, he's playing at Carnegie Hall. So you know I mean it all fell into place. I was lucky.

MR: That's nice. Did you have a sense of what it meant to "make it" in the music business? When you were 22 did you have specific goals or like most of us where you're just sort of like taking what comes and try to be prepared?

MS: No I mean you know like before I got my first record date I knew what I had to be doing. And worked at that. So I just always knew what you had to do. You had to work very hard at this thing, and I still work hard at it. I'm still doing it. You know because what I

used to do is do a lot of transcribing of solos. I haven't done it in a while but I put in my work doing that. And not only piano players, horn players you know, different people. But transcribing it always made it easier for me.

MR: I see LPs behind you and I have my share. Do you ever indulge your memories of those LPs and take them into a class and say look students, you see this? This is how I learned.

MS: That's right. I mean I don't take the records into school but you know now it's Spotify you know or something. And I say if you want to learn this tune check out the various recordings of this tune on Spotify. And really listen to them and see what you can do.

MR: Anything surprise you about the current jazz students that you didn't expect?

MS: You know what? They're playing their butts off. I mean they're really, I mean this group that I have with Sonny Rollins, man, I mean the level that they're, there's two tenor players in this band, piano, bass and drums. They're all playing so well and I tell them that. They're really — I mean when I was that age I don't know if I was playing that well. You know? The way they — whatever they're doing they're doing something right because, and when they get into the real world they're going to be ready. And I try to encourage that. I didn't have teachers who were like that. I didn't have teachers that encouraged me. They just said do what you do. You know, whatever. But I tell my students, especially this band, that they're great. I don't want them to get big heads but they're doing something right and it should be encouraged.

MR: That's very hopeful. I'm going to wrap up soon, I know you have other commitments.

MS: Okay.

MR: Do you feel, how do I put this, does music have the power to change people's minds in a positive way?

MS: Definitely. It really does change people's minds in a positive way. And it certainly has done that for me, so it's a great thing.

MR: When you're at Small's tonight I hope that the audience hears things in your original compositions that you heard.

MS: Uh huh. I hope so too. Yeah I think they will. I really think they will. Because there's something I think in my music that appeals to people. Whatever it is I think the lyrical side of my music and that has something to do with it.

MR: Yeah. I've always, for myself, I make — it's not a judgement it's an observation almost — that when a song is over if I can sing the melody back to myself that's important to me.

MS: It is.

MR: Yeah.

MS: I think they'd be able to sing the melodies.

MR: Good.

MS: Yeah.

MR: I just had my sax students learn a Sonny Rollins tune by ear, it's a little more current, it's called "Island Lady" —

MS: Okay, yeah.

MR: And it's so hooky that — now I can't get it out of my head.

MS: Yeah. Well I mean with Sonny Rollins' music, definitely hooky. Because I mean a lot of his music is really like dance music. And calypso is basically dance music.

MR: Yeah, okay.

MS: And that's what I tell my students.

MR: Well I have enjoyed our conversation and I wish you the best of continued success.

MS: Thank you so much.

MR: Yeah.

MS: Is there going to be a link with this?

MR: Yes. We will put this on our YouTube channel and I think you'll be happy.

MS: Okay. I'm sure I will be.

MR: Good. Excellent. I'll sign off and then we will say our good-byes.

MS: Okay Monk. Nice meeting you. Nice taking part in this. It's really been great. You've come up with some good questions.

MR: Thank you very much.

MS: Yeah it's great.